

KS₃: HISTORY OF AUSTRALIA

COURSE TEXTBOOK & TEXTBOOK

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L1: Claiming Australia

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the dual purpose of James Cook's voyage, contrasting the public scientific mission with the secret government orders to claim territory.
- ☐ Analyse the indispensable navigational and diplomatic contributions of the Polynesian high priest and master star navigator, Tupaia.
- ☐ Evaluate the first encounter at Botany Bay in 1770 from both the British perspective and the defensive spiritual perspective of the Gweagal people.

Do Now Activity

1. What cash crop drove the transatlantic slave trade and brought immense wealth to British traders and plantation owners in the seventeenth century?
2. Which Tudor queen granted royal charters to English adventurers like Sir Walter Raleigh to explore and claim lands in the Americas in the 1580s?
3. What dramatic population shift occurred in Great Britain between 1750 and 1850 as a direct result of the Industrial Revolution?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Ancestors | Botany Bay | Colony | Gweagal | Navigator | Royal Society

In August 1768, Captain James Cook set sail on the Endeavour, funded by the _____ to observe the stars. In April 1770, the ship arrived on the east coast of Australia at a place they named _____. Here, they had a tense first meeting with the _____ people, whose _____ had lived on that coastline for thousands of years. Cook eventually sailed north and claimed the land as a British _____ called New South Wales, guided along the way by a master Polynesian _____ named Tupaia.

A Portrait of Captain James Cook

Source A: A portrait of Captain James Cook, painted by Nathaniel Dance-Holland in 1776.

Secret Instructions to Captain Cook

"You are also with the Consent of the Natives to take possession of Convenient Situations in the Country in the Name of the King of Great Britain; or, if you find the Country uninhabited take Possession for His Majesty by setting up Proper Marks and Inscriptions, as first discoverers and possessors."

Source B: Extract from the Secret Instructions issued to Captain James Cook by the British Admiralty, 1768.

In August 1768, Lieutenant James Cook, an officer in the British Navy, left Plymouth on his ship, the Endeavour. This voyage was destined to change global history. Publicly, the journey was funded and framed as a peaceful mission of scientific discovery. On board were nine scientists from the prestigious [Royal Society], led by the wealthy and influential young botanist Sir Joseph Banks. Their official, public

task was to travel to the South Pacific island of Tahiti to observe the transit of the planet Venus across the Sun. By timing this event from different parts of the world, scientists hoped to calculate the exact distance between the Earth and the Sun.

However, scientific curiosity was only a cover story. Cook also carried a packet of secret instructions from the British Admiralty. These private orders commanded him that once the scientific observations in Tahiti were complete, he was to sail further south into the uncharted waters of the Pacific to search for a rumored, massive landmass known as the 'Great Southern Land.' If he located this land, he was ordered to map its coastline, record its resources, and claim it for the British Crown before other rival European nations, like France or Spain, could do so.

While British history books have celebrated Captain Cook's navigational genius for centuries, the survival and success of the Endeavour relied heavily on an extraordinary Indigenous figure: Tupaia. Joining the ship in Tahiti in 1769 at the urging of Joseph Banks, Tupaia was a high priest and master star navigator from the island of Ra'iatea. While Cook possessed state-of-the-art European maritime instruments like sextants, compasses, and marine clocks, he had no charts or understanding of the vast, complex, and dangerous Pacific reefs.

Tupaia possessed an exceptional, complex mental map spanning over 3,000 miles of ocean. He navigated using ancient, highly sophisticated Polynesian star navigation techniques. Without any mechanical tools, Tupaia could determine the ship's exact position by reading the stars, the path of the sun, bird flight patterns, cloud formations, and the unique temperature and vibration of ocean currents. Furthermore, Tupaia was a brilliant diplomat. As the only person on board who could speak languages closely related to the Pacific islanders, he served as a translator when the Endeavour reached New Zealand. He communicated directly with the Māori, defusing highly dangerous misunderstandings and preventing what would have been catastrophic colonial massacres. Despite saving the lives of the crew and creating a detailed chart of the islands, Tupaia's pivotal role was written out of mainstream history for over 250 years, leaving his story largely 'invisible.'

In April 1770, the Endeavour sailed up the eastern coast of Australia. Although Dutch explorers had mapped parts of the western coast in the seventeenth century, they had never claimed ownership of the land. When Cook's crew located a sheltered bay and rowed toward the shore, they were met by two Gweagal Aboriginal men of the Dharawal nation armed with spears and shields. The Gweagal's ancestors had lived in harmony with that land for over 65,000 years.

From the spiritual and legal perspective of the Gweagal, it was their sacred duty to protect their ancestral country from uninvited strangers who did not have permission to be there. Cook wrote in his journal that when one of the Gweagal men threw a rock to warn them away, the British fired a warning musket. When the warriors stood their ground and a spear was thrown, the British fired two more times with buckshot, wounding one of the Gweagal men in the leg. Cook framed this in his records as an unprovoked attack by 'natives' on peaceful explorers, completely ignoring that the British were armed invaders. The Endeavour stayed in the bay for a week. Sir Joseph Banks and his scientists were so amazed by the thousands of unknown botanical specimens they collected that they named the place 'Botany Bay.' In May, Cook sailed north to an island he named 'Possession Island,' where he raised the Union Jack and claimed the entire eastern coast for Britain, naming it 'New South Wales' under the legal fiction of 'Terra Nullius' (nobody's land).

Active Tasks

Q1.

L2: Creating a Convict Colony

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how the loss of the American colonies in 1776 directly caused a prison crisis in Britain that led to the system of transportation.
- ☐ Describe the physical and environmental challenges faced by Captain Arthur Phillip and the convicts during their first year at Sydney Cove.
- ☐ Analyse the work and social conditions of the convicts, contrasting general labor with the punishments of the chain road gangs.

Do Now Activity

1. What was the secret reason the British Admiralty gave Captain Cook private instructions to explore the South Pacific?
2. Who was the master Polynesian star navigator and high priest who used his mental map of the ocean to guide the Endeavour?
3. What did the Gweagal Aboriginal warriors throw at Captain Cook's men during their first meeting at Botany Bay in 1770?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Convict | Governor | Hard labour | Hulk | Transportation | Sydney Harbour

Your Sentence:

Prison Hulks on the Thames

Source C: An 1806 sketch by Edward William Cooke depicting prison hulks moored in the Thames.

During the eighteenth century, the British legal system relied heavily on the Transportation Act of 1717 to deal with criminals. Under this system, the courts sentenced thousands of petty thieves to be sent to Britain's colonies in North America, where their labor was sold to tobacco plantation owners. However, in 1776, the American colonies declared their independence from Great Britain. This political revolution meant that sending British criminals to America was no longer possible, creating a severe and immediate prison crisis back in Britain.

British gaols quickly became dangerously overcrowded. To cope with this, the government passed the Hulks Act of 1776, which allowed them to lock prisoners inside 'hulks'—old, decommissioned warships moored in southern English ports like Portsmouth and Plymouth. These floating prisons were horrific: they were dark, suffocatingly hot, filthy, and disease-ridden, with thousands of prisoners dying of typhus and cholera. As public panic rose over the disease and frequent prison escapes, the British government realized they needed a permanent, distant alternative. In August 1786, they decided to establish a new penal colony on the eastern coast of Australia, which Captain Cook had claimed eighteen years earlier.

In May 1787, the First Fleet—a group of eleven ships carrying approximately 1,400 people, including 750 convicts, marines, and sailors—departed Portsmouth under the command of Captain Arthur Phillip, who was appointed as the colony's first [Governor]. After an arduous, eight-month voyage, the fleet reached Botany Bay in January 1788. Phillip quickly realized the bay was too shallow and open to heavy winds, so he sailed slightly north to Port Jackson, establishing the settlement of Sydney Cove on January 26, 1788.

The arrival was marked by extreme physical and social chaos. On Wednesday, February 6, 1788, the

female convicts were finally brought ashore from their transport ships. Arthur Bowes Smyth, a naval surgeon aboard the Lady Penrhyn (the ship carrying the majority of the female convicts), kept a highly detailed, eyewitness journal of that day. He recorded that as the women landed, a violent, terrifying tropical thunderstorm struck Sydney Cove, splitting a massive tree in the center of the camp and killing several sheep. Smyth described scenes of absolute riot and heavy drinking as sailors and male convicts broke into the women's tents. Bowes Smyth's journals are invaluable to historians today because they provide a rare, human face to the female convicts, recording their actual names, ages, trades, and personal struggles during the settlement's birth.

The first year of the Sydney settlement was an intense struggle for survival. The colonists faced immediate starvation because the sandy soil around Sydney Cove was poor, the local climate was completely unfamiliar, and there were almost no skilled farmers, blacksmiths, or carpenters among the convicts. To prevent a total collapse and preserve order, Governor Phillip took the radical step of ordering that all food supplies be rationed completely equally between the officers, soldiers, and convicts.

To build the colony from scratch, every convict was forced into grueling [Hard labour]. During the day, they felled massive trees, cleared dense bush, grew food, and quarried sandstone blocks to construct the first barracks. Convicts who refused to work, stole food, or committed other offenses were severely punished. Many were sent to join a 'road gang'—forced to work day after day with their legs locked in heavy iron chains, breaking stones and shoveling earth to build Australia's first roads. Despite this brutal regime, by the 1820s, this forced manual labor had successfully transformed the wild bushland of Sydney into a thriving, highly profitable colonial port.

Active Tasks

Q1.

L3: Encounters with the Indigenous Peoples

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Contrast the humanitarian intentions of King George III's official 1788 instructions with the actual practices of physical and ecological dispossession committed by British settlers.
- ☐ Explain the devastating impacts of European diseases and environmental changes on the Aboriginal way of life, with a specific focus on the Eora nation around Sydney.
- ☐ Evaluate the role of Eora warrior Pemulwuy in leading armed resistance, and analyze the colonial collection of Aboriginal human remains for British scientific institutions.

Do Now Activity

1. Why did the American War of Independence in 1776 force the British government to find a new penal colony in Australia?
2. Explain how Tupaia navigated the Endeavour across 3,000 miles of ocean without any European instruments.
3. What radical rationing system did Governor Arthur Phillip introduce during the First Fleet's first year of starvation at Sydney Cove in 1788?

Vocabulary Check

Watkin Tench on Pemulwuy

"Pemulwuy was a man of the woods, a bold, independent, and active character... He had been a most active enemy to the settlers, and had speared several of them... He was a formidable foe, and the terror of the colony."

Source D: An extract from the journal of Watkin Tench, a British marine officer, describing the Aboriginal resistance leader Pemulwuy.

When the British arrived in 1788, Australia was home to over 300,000 Aboriginal people divided into hundreds of distinct tribes, speaking different languages and living on ancestral lands they had occupied for at least 65,000 years. The Eora nation was the traditional custodian of the coastal region around Sydney Cove. The British settlers, viewing the land through a European lens, saw no stone houses, no fences, and no intensive crop-farming. They concluded that the Aboriginal people were primitive wanderers who had no legal claim to the land.

This cultural ignorance birthed the legal myth of 'Terra Nullius' (nobody's land), which the British government used to claim sole ownership of the entire continent. In reality, Aboriginal Australians had managed the landscape with immense sophistication for millennia. They used 'firestick farming'—highly controlled seasonal burning—to clear undergrowth, encourage new grass that attracted game, and prevent catastrophic bushfires. In river systems, they constructed elaborate stone canals up to a mile and a half long to manage waterways and cultivate massive eel fisheries. For Aboriginal people, land was not real estate to be bought and sold; it was a deeply [Spiritual] entity. Taking their land was not just a loss of property; it was a form of spiritual death.

Before the First Fleet left England, King George III issued official instructions to Governor Arthur Phillip, commanding him to protect the native populations and live in [Amity] and kindness with them, declaring that anyone who cruelly destroyed them should be punished. However, as British settlement expanded, this official policy collapsed completely. The most immediate devastation came from invisible invaders: European diseases. In 1789, a catastrophic epidemic of [Smallpox] swept through the Eora nation. Having no natural immunity, up to half of the coastal Aboriginal population died within a single year, leaving the shorelines littered with unburied bodies.

As free settlers took over the interior, they cut down native forests, built fences across ancient pathways, and drove away native animals to make way for vast herds of cows and sheep. This ecological destruction cut off the Aboriginal food and water supplies, forcing them to hunt the settlers' livestock to survive. The resulting 'frontier wars' were incredibly brutal. In Tasmania in the 1820s, Governor George Arthur tried to restore order by nailing posters to trees promising equal justice, yet local settlers were permitted to hunt and shoot Tasmanian Aboriginal people like vermin, resulting in a near-total genocide. Similarly, in 1838 at the Myall Creek Massacre, a group of eleven armed white stockmen rounded up twenty-eight unarmed Aboriginal men, women, and children, slaughtered them with muskets and swords, and burned their bodies on a massive pyre.

Aboriginal Australians did not accept this invasion passively. From 1790 onwards, a formidable Eora warrior named Pemulwuy led a sophisticated, twelve-year guerrilla war of resistance against the British. Pemulwuy organized raids on government crop farms, destroyed settlers' crops, killed imported livestock to cripple the colonial economy, and attacked armed patrols with spears. In December 1790, Pemulwuy fatally speared Governor Phillip's favorite gamekeeper. In retaliation, Governor Phillip ordered Watkin Tench to lead a punitive military expedition of over fifty armed men carrying hatchets to capture Pemulwuy and bring back his head, alongside the heads of ten other warriors. However, Pemulwuy's warriors easily evaded the heavy, insect-ravaged British troops in the bush, forcing Phillip to write to London apologizing that he could not send back a head.

The hunt for Pemulwuy was fueled by a dark, scientific demand in Britain. Sir Joseph Banks, the

celebrated botanist who had sailed with Captain Cook, used his immense political influence in London to demand that Australian governors send him 'human specimens'—specifically Aboriginal skulls and bones—to distribute to European museums and scientists. In 1802, Pemulwuy was finally shot and killed by British settlers. His head was severed from his body and preserved in a cask of spirits. It was shipped to England as a personal gift from Governor Philip Gidley King to Sir Joseph Banks. Customs officers in England discovered the head during a routine inspection of the spirits cask, causing a brief local newspaper scandal, before Banks quietly deposited his 'trophy' into the museum of his close friend, the surgeon John Hunter.

Active Tasks

Q1.

L4: From Penal Colony to Settlement

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the significance of James Ruse's farming experiments at Rose Hill in proving the colony's agricultural viability.
- ☐ Analyse how Gregory Blaxland's crossing of the Blue Mountains in 1813 unlocked the interior of the continent for the Merino sheep industry.
- ☐ Evaluate how the discovery of gold in 1851 and the subsequent influx of Chinese and European miners brought about the end of convict transportation.

Do Now Activity

1. What was the name of the Eora resistance leader who fatally speared Governor Phillip's gamekeeper and led a twelve-year guerrilla war?
2. How did the Gweagal warriors view the landing of Captain Cook's men at Botany Bay in 1770?
3. Identify two European diseases that devastated Aboriginal populations because they had no natural immunity.

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Blue Mountains | Free settlers | Gold prospector | Merino | Self-sufficient | Whaling industry

By the early 1800s, Australia was changing rapidly. Freed convicts like James Ruse proved that individuals could become _____ farmers. The introduction of Spanish _____ sheep brought massive profits, driving sheep farmers to cross the rugged _____ in search of grazing land. Meanwhile, the _____ turned Sydney into a busy port. The biggest change occurred in 1851 when a _____ named Edward Hargreaves discovered gold, triggering a massive gold rush of _____ and ending transportation forever.

The Australian Gold Rush

Source E: An 1852 illustration showing prospectors panning for gold during the Australian gold rushes.

In November 1788, a freed convict named James Ruse, who had completed his sentence for burglary, was given a small, clearing plot of land inland from Sydney Cove at a place named Rose Hill (later Parramatta). Governor Arthur Phillip was desperate to find out if the colony could survive without receiving constant, expensive food shipments from Britain. Ruse worked the land with exceptional grit. Lacking horses or heavy metal ploughs, he used simple hand tools to clear the dense timber, burned the felled trees to enrich the poor, sandy soil with wood ash, and carefully hoed the earth to sow wheat.

His experiment was a complete triumph. By 1791, Ruse proved that he could support himself and his wife Perry, becoming completely [Self-sufficient]. He was officially recorded as Australia's first successful free farmer. His success proved to the British government that the colony could survive, prompting the first waves of voluntary free immigrants to leave Britain's crowded cities to establish their own farms in the young colony.

While basic crops kept the settlers alive, it was wool that made the colony incredibly wealthy. A small flock of English sheep had arrived with the First Fleet, but they did not survive the damp coastal climate. The turning point came in 1797, when twenty-six Spanish [Merino] sheep arrived in Sydney on a supply ship from South Africa. Merino sheep were world-famous for producing exceptionally soft, thick, and highly valuable wool. They flourished in the dry Australian pastures, and sheep farmers quickly realized they could make massive fortunes exporting raw wool back to the mechanized textile mills of industrial northern England.

However, by 1810, the flat grasslands surrounding Sydney were exhausted by drought and insect plagues. Expansion was blocked to the west by a formidable geographic barrier: the high, rugged, and heavily forested [Blue Mountains]. For twenty-five years, explorers had failed to cross them. In 1813, a determined farmer named Gregory Blaxland, alongside two friends and three convicts, set off on a new route. By following the high mountain ridges rather than the deep valleys, they became the first Europeans to successfully cross the range. Beyond the peaks, they discovered vast, highly fertile grazing lands. By 1820, over 114 sheep farmers had crossed the mountains, establishing Australia's first inland agricultural town at Bathurst in 1815 and driving a massive expansion of the wool trade.

At the same time, the [Whaling industry] was transforming Sydney Cove from a remote penal outpost into a thriving, busy international trading port. In late eighteenth-century Britain, the Industrial Revolution was in full swing, creating a massive commercial demand for whale oil. This oil was essential to lubricate the heavy steam-powered machines in northern factories and to fill the public streetlamps that illuminated Britain's expanding cities.

In 1791, a fleet of private whaling ships had been contracted to transport convicts to Sydney. Once their human cargo was unloaded, the captains sailed into the South Pacific to hunt whales, using Sydney as their base of operations. The whalers melted down the whale blubber on board and exported barrels of high-grade machine-lubricating oil back to London, bringing immense profits to the colony. At its peak between 1820 and 1850, over 1,300 professional whalers worked out of Sydney Harbour each year, generating the capital and trading links that allowed Australia to thrive economically.

The final and most dramatic transformation of Australia occurred in February 1851, when an experienced [Gold prospector] named Edward Hargreaves discovered specks of 'payable gold' in a river near Bathurst, 250 kilometers west of Sydney. This discovery triggered a massive, frenzied gold rush. Within months, thousands of local workers abandoned their regular jobs in Sydney, and ships carrying over 100,000 voluntary immigrants from Great Britain, America, and continental Europe arrived in Australia to find fortune.

This gold rush included a massive wave of Chinese migration. By 1861, over 38,000 Chinese immigrants had sailed to Australia, referring to the country as 'Xin Jin Shan' (the New Gold Mountain). Working in high-yield districts like Lambing Flat and Braidwood, the Chinese miners were highly disciplined and invented new techniques, such as using 'cradles' to wash larger amounts of gravel, though they faced severe racial resentment and violent riots from white miners. This sudden, immense mineral wealth brought an immediate end to the convict system. The British government realized that transportation was meant to be a terrifying, deterrent punishment for criminals. If a convicted thief could serve their

sentence and immediately become a wealthy gold digger in a prosperous land, transportation no longer worked as a punishment. Convict transportation to New South Wales was stopped in 1851, transforming Australia permanently into a democratic nation of free citizens.

Active Tasks

Q1.